

DREAMING AGES HISTORY · EPISODE 4

Ancient Greece

A Calm Journey Across the Aegean

✦ ✦ ✦

A BEDTIME COMPANION

Two maps, a timeline from the palaces of Crete to the coming of Rome, the people and places you'll meet in the episode, and a short list of trusted books, museums and podcasts, for the evenings when you would like to wander a little further.

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The Greek mainland and the Aegean

Let's begin with the mountains, the islands and the sea.



Ancient sites plotted at their real locations on a modern base map (Natural Earth). Coastlines are modern; some, such as the bay at Troy and the pass at Thermopylae, have changed a great deal since antiquity.

AT A GLANCE

- Greece was never one country
- Hundreds of city-states grew up in mountain valleys and on islands and coasts
- They were linked by the sea
- They shared a language, gods and festivals

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Places you'll visit in the episode

Ten places from the episode, from Crete to Macedon.

Knossos · The great Minoan palace on Crete, with painted corridors and a central court.

Mycenae · The walled citadel of the Bronze Age Greeks, whose palaces fell around 1200 BCE.

Olympia · Sanctuary of Zeus, home of the games, traditionally first held in 776 BCE.

Delphi · Apollo's sanctuary on the slopes of Mount Parnassus, seat of the oracle.

Sparta · The city of the Spartiates, two kings, ephors and the agoge.

Athens · The city of Cleisthenes and Pericles, crowned by the Parthenon on its Acropolis.

Marathon · The plain where Athenians and Plataeans defeated a Persian force in 490 BCE.

Thermopylae · Salamis · The narrow pass and the sea battle of 480 BCE.

Epidaurus · Sanctuary of Asclepius, the god of healing, with its great theatre.

Pella · Capital of Macedon, birthplace of Alexander.

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TWO THOUSAND YEARS, SLOWLY

A timeline of the Greek world

Two thousand years of the Greek world, one quiet step at a time.

AT A GLANCE

508/507 BCE
Cleisthenes' reforms

480 · 479 BCE
Thermopylae and Salamis

336–323 BCE
Alexander's reign

146 BCE
Roman rule

Early dates are approximate; "ancient Greece" here runs from the Bronze Age to the Roman conquest.

c. 1900 BCE	The first Minoan palaces rise on Crete, Knossos among them.
c. 1600–1100 BCE	The Mycenaean age; Linear B records an early form of Greek.
c. 1200 BCE	The Bronze Age palaces collapse, for reasons still debated.
776 BCE	The first Olympic games, by tradition.
8th c. BCE	The alphabet is adapted from Phoenician; Homer's epics take shape.
594 BCE	Solon's reforms at Athens.
508/507 BCE	Cleisthenes' reforms lay the foundations of Athenian democracy.
499 BCE	The Ionian Revolt against Persia.
490 BCE	Marathon.
480 · 479 BCE	Thermopylae and Salamis; then Plataea and Mycale.

TWO THOUSAND YEARS, SLOWLY

A timeline of the Greek world

The story goes on from here, slowly.



478 BCE	The Delian League is formed, later an Athenian empire.
447–432 BCE	The Parthenon is built.
431–404 BCE	The Peloponnesian War; plague strikes Athens in 430.
415–413 BCE	The Sicilian Expedition ends in disaster.
399 BCE	The trial and death of Socrates.
371 · 338 BCE	Thebes defeats Sparta at Leuctra; Philip II wins at Chaeronea.
336–323 BCE	Alexander's reign; he dies in Babylon.
Third century BCE	Alexandria's Library and Museum flourish; Euclid works there.
212 BCE	Archimedes dies at Syracuse.
146 BCE	Rome destroys Corinth; Greece passes under Roman rule.

From the Aegean to the Indus

Now let's step back and see how far the Greek world reached.



Approximate extent of Alexander's empire at his death in 323 BCE, simplified from the open historical-basemaps dataset; borders are approximate. Long before, Greek colonies such as Massalia (Marseille), Syracuse and Byzantion had spread around the Mediterranean and the Black Sea.

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People you'll meet

The poets, thinkers and leaders you'll hear about along the way.

Homer · The poet, or tradition of poets, of the Iliad and the Odyssey.

Solon · Athenian lawgiver of the early 500s BCE.

Cleisthenes · Reformer whose changes of 508/507 BCE began Athenian democracy.

Leonidas · Spartan king who fell at Thermopylae in 480 BCE.

Themistocles · Athenian who built the fleet that won at Salamis.

Pericles · Leading Athenian of the mid-400s, behind the building of the Acropolis.

Herodotus · Historian of the Persian Wars.

Sophocles · Tragic poet of Athens, beside Aeschylus and Euripides.

Socrates · Philosopher of Athens, tried and put to death in 399 BCE.

Plato · Aristotle · Plato founded the Academy; his student Aristotle, the Lyceum.

Alexander the Great · King of Macedon from 336 BCE; died in Babylon in 323 BCE.

Archimedes · Mathematician and engineer of Syracuse; died in 212 BCE.

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WHILE YOU LISTEN

Things to spot, legend and history

A few things to listen for, and a note on legend and history.

THINGS TO SPOT IN THE EPISODE

- The painted corridors and central court of Knossos
- Linear B, an early form of Greek
- Apollo's oracle on the slopes of Mount Parnassus
- The Parthenon on the Acropolis
- Archimedes, the mathematician and engineer of Syracuse

LEGEND OR HISTORY?

Some famous stories sit between myth and history: the Trojan War, Homer as one single poet, and the "three hundred" at Thermopylae (thousands of other Greeks fought there too). The date 776 BCE for the first Olympics is a later tradition. The episode keeps these apart from what the sources and archaeology show.





Artistic impressions of the court at Knossos and of the sanctuary of Delphi, made for the episode. They are not historical records.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Books to read

If you'd like to wander a little further, here are some trusted places to start.

Introducing the Ancient Greeks ↗, Edith Hall (W. W. Norton, 2015).

Ancient Greece: A Very Short Introduction ↗, Paul Cartledge (Oxford University Press, 2011).

The Hemlock Cup: Socrates, Athens and the Search for the Good Life ↗, Bettany Hughes (Knopf, 2011).

The Histories ↗, Herodotus, trans. Tom Holland (Penguin Classics, 2015).

The Landmark Thucydides ↗, ed. Robert B. Strassler (Free Press, 1998).

The Odyssey ↗, Homer, trans. Robert Fagles (Penguin).

📚 FIND THESE BOOKS — TAP HERE →

Full reading list ↗

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Museums, places and podcasts

Museums & places

Acropolis Museum, Athens.

National Archaeological Museum, Athens: the finds from Mycenae.

British Museum, London: the Parthenon sculptures.

Royal Ontario Museum, Toronto: the Gallery of Greece.

Podcasts

The History of Ancient Greece, Ryan Stitt: a deep, narrative history from the Bronze Age onward.

A BEDTIME QUESTION

If you could spend one evening in a single place from this companion, would it be Knossos, Delphi or the Acropolis?

"Tonight that conversation softens into hush. The oars are shipped. The harbour is still."

LISTEN TO THE FULL EPISODE, AND FIND THE NEXT ONE

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Dreaming Ages History · Narration is AI-generated text-to-speech; illustrations are AI-generated artistic impressions. Facts follow the episode script and its sources. Maps drawn from real coordinates: Natural Earth; historical borders simplified from the open historical-basemaps dataset (A. Ourednik). Free for personal use. Sleep well. 🌙